

LinguaLounge IPA Reference Sheet: Spanish

Base language: English - / / = broad phonemic IPA, [] = common phonetic realization.
Regional pronunciation can vary.

Scope

General Latin American Spanish with seseo. In much of northern and central Spain, z and c before e/i are /θ/ instead of /s/.

VOWELS

Category	IPA symbols
Vowels	/a e i o u/
Glides	/j w/ in diphthongs such as bien /bjen/ and fuego /'fwexo/
Stress marks	' before the stressed syllable: café /ka'fe/

CONSONANTS

Category	IPA symbols
Plosives	/p t k b d g/
Fricatives	/f s x ʝ/ plus [β ð ɣ] as common allophones
Affricate	/tʃ/
Nasals	/m n ɲ/
Liquids	/l ɾ r/

ALPHABET AND COMMON SPELLING VALUES

The table gives common learner-safe values. Some letters have additional values in loanwords, names, or regional speech.

Letter / spelling	Main IPA value	Example	Notes
A a	/a/	amor /a'mor/	
B b	/b/	bebé /be'be/ [be'βe]	Same phoneme as v.
C c	/s/ or /k/	cena /'sena/, casa /'kasa/	Before e/i -> /s/ in seseo; otherwise /k/.
Ch ch	/tʃ/	chico /'tʃiko/	
D d	/d/	dedo /'dedo/ ['deðo]	Often [ð] between vowels.
E e	/e/	mesa /'mesa/	
F f	/f/	fuego /'fweɣo/	
G g	/x/ or /g/	gente /'xente/, gato /'gato/	Before e/i -> /x/; otherwise /g/.
Gu gu	/g/ or /gw/	guerra /'gera/, guapo /'gwapo/	u is silent in gue/gui unless written ü.
H h	silent	hacer /a'ser/	
I i	/i/	imposible /impo'sible/	
J j	/x/	jamón /xa'mon/	
K k	/k/	kilo /'kilo/	Mostly loanwords.
L l	/l/	lago /'laɣo/	
Li ll	/ʎ/	lluvia /'juβja/	Most dialects have yeísmo; some keep /ʎ/.
M m	/m/	madre /'maðre/	
N n	/n/	nada /'naða/	
Ñ ñ	/ɲ/	niño /'nino/	
O o	/o/	oscuro /os'kuro/	
P p	/p/	padre /'paðre/	
Q q	/k/	queso /'keso/	qu before e/i = /k/.
R r	/r/ or /ɾ/	rama /'rama/, pero /'pero/	Word-initial r is trill /r/.
Rr rr	/r/	perro /'pero/	Doubled rr is trill.
S s	/s/	serpiente /ser'pjente/	
T t	/t/	tarde /'tarðe/	
U u	/u/	último /'ultimo/	
V v	/b/	vaso /'baso/	Same phoneme as b.
W w	/w/ or /u/	whisky /'wiski/	Mostly loanwords.
X x	/ks/	explicar /ekspli'kar/	Can vary in specific names, e.g. México /'mexiko/.
Y y	/j/ or /i/	yo /jo/, y /i/	Consonant before a vowel; vowel when alone.
Z z	/s/	zona /'sona/	In much of Spain, /θ/.

IMPORTANT SPELLING AND PRONUNCIATION NOTES

Vowels	Spanish vowels are stable and do not reduce like English unstressed vowels.
b/v, d, g allophones	b/v, d, and g are often softer between vowels: [β ð ɣ]. The broad phonemes remain /b d g/.
Written accent	If stress breaks the normal pattern, it is written with an acute accent: <i>café</i> /ka'fe/, <i>lápiz</i> /'lapis/.
Dieresis	In <i>güe/güi</i> , <i>ü</i> means the u is pronounced: <i>pingüino</i> /piŋ'gwino/.